whereas U^{235} undergoes fission. Hence, U^{235} is a fissionable material and U^{238} is non-fissionable.

There are some radioactive elements, which can be converted into fissionable material. They are called as **fertile materials**.

E.g.: Uranium-238, Thorium-232, Plutonium-240.

6.3.3 Chain Reaction

A uranium nucleus (U-235) when bombarded with a neutron undergoes fission producing three neutrons. These three neutrons in turn can cause fission in three other uranium nuclei present in the sample, thus producing nine neutrons. These nine neutrons in turn may produce twenty seven neutrons and so on. This is known as 'chain reaction'. A chain reaction is a self-propagating process in which the number of neutrons goes on multiplying rapidly almost in a geometrical progression.

Two kinds of chain reactions are possible. They are: (i) controlled chain reaction and (ii)uncontrolled chain reaction.

(a) Controlled chain reaction

In the controlled chain reaction the number of neutrons released is maintained to be one. This is achieved by absorbing the extra neutrons with a neutron absorber leaving only one neutron to produce further fission. Thus, the reaction is sustained in a controlled manner. The energy released due to a controlled chain reaction can be utilized for constructive purposes. Controlled chain reaction is used in a nuclear reactor to produce energy in a sustained and controlled manner.

(b) Uncontrolled chain reaction

In the uncontrolled chain reaction the number of neutrons multiplies indefinitely and causes fission in a large amount of the fissile material. This results in the release of a huge amount of energy within a fraction of a second. This kind of chain reaction is used in the atom bomb to produce an explosion. Figure 6.3 represents an uncontrolled chain reaction.

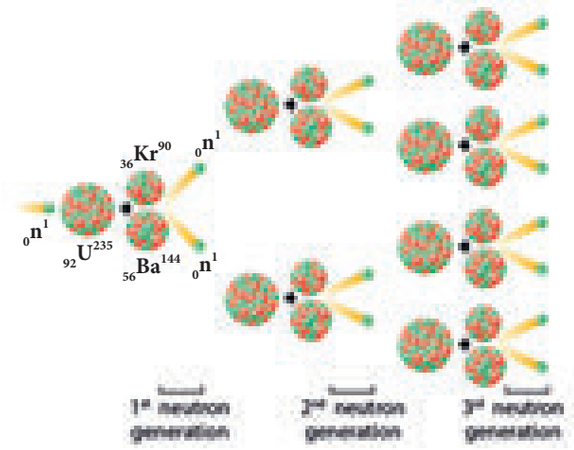


Figure 6.3 Uncontrolled chain reaction

6.3.4 Critical Mass

During a nuclear fission process, about 2 to 3 neutrons are released. But, all these neutrons may not be available to produce further fission. Some of them may escape from the system, which is termed as 'leakage of neutrons' and some may be absorbed by the non-fissionable materials present in the system. These two factors lead to the loss of neutrons. To sustain the chain reaction, the rate of production of neutrons due to nuclear fission must be more than the rate of its loss. This can be achieved only when the size (i.e., mass) of the fissionable material is equal to a certain optimum value. This is known as 'critical mass'.

The minimum mass of a fissile material necessary to sustain the chain reaction is called 'critical mass (m_c)'. It depends on the nature, density and the size of the fissile material.

If the mass of the fissile material is less than the critical mass, it is termed as 'subcritical'. If the mass of the fissile material is more than the critical mass, it is termed as 'supercritical'.

Activity 6.2

Using beads make a chain reaction model

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